



Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship

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5 June 2020

Lesley Cormack, PhD
Dean of Arts
University of Alberta
Edmonton, AB T6G 2R3

Dear Dean Cormack,

I am writing as president of the Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS), an organization of university faculty members and others dedicated to the defense of academic freedom and the merit principle in higher education. (For further information, please see our website at www.safs.ca.)

According to a blog posting by Carolyn Sale, an English professor at your university, you recently removed Kathleen Lowrey, an associate professor in Anthropology, from her position as Anthropology's associate chair, undergraduate programs. Dr Sale's post is available here: <https://cfe.ryerson.ca/people/carolyn-sale>

Dr Sale contends that you removed Dr Lowrey from her position because some students complained that some of Dr Lowrey's views and her advocacy of them made them feel "unsafe."

If Dr Sale is correct, then the University of Alberta has severely compromised its mission to help students to become at home in the world of ideas and disputation. While students who object to Dr Lowrey's views should be encouraged to challenge and criticize them, they should also come to know that professors with whom they disagree can fulfil service duties toward them and be conscientious mentors.

Removing Dr Lowrey will likely have effects detrimental to the operation and the mission of the University of Alberta. Faculty members will be less inclined to assume service roles if they believe that remaining in those roles is contingent on their staying away from controversy. They might, indeed, choose to avoid controversy even in their teaching, having got the message that students who do not like what they hear may complain to the dean. This is especially true if, as Dr Sale reports, you believe that universities must balance academic freedom with a "safe" learning environment.

Dr Sale writes that one motive in removing Dr Lowrey from her service position is to prevent University of Alberta students from electing not to take Anthropology courses. Neither academic departments nor individual professors should be forced by their university to worry about the financial consequences of choices made on academic grounds. The task for deans and other administrators is to help students acquire academic values so that they might themselves make decisions on academic grounds.

The removal of Dr Lowrey from her position as associate chair, undergraduate programs, in Anthropology misidentifies the duties academic administrators have toward students and it will likely diminish the quality of service students receive from professors, it could harm teaching, and it threatens the academic integrity of the University of Alberta. For these reasons, we ask that you reinstate Dr Lowrey to her service role in Anthropology.

We respectfully request that you respond to our letter. With your permission, we will post your response along with this letter on our website.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Mark Mercer', with a stylized, flowing script.

Mark Mercer, PhD
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Kathleen Lowrey, Associate Professor, Anthropology, University of Alberta